deputy, was rewarded with the post of Minister of State Security. Wolfgang Herger, a member of the Central Committee of the SED, remembered Mielke as a tiny man with a pudgy babyish face and a constant smile that gave him the look of a mischievous, overweight kid. Whether in a car or boat, train or plane, office, or conference, or even the bathroom, Mielke's flow of instructions and commentary never ceased. Herger amplified this image, observing:

When we Germans do something, we do it thoroughly! […] If there is someone at the head of the Ministry for State Security for whom ideological diversion is the decisive factor, then gigantic apparatuses are set up and expanded to combat them, and with all conceivable thoroughness. […] And Erich Mielke was, as far as that is concerned, a very typical German who really organised everything from top to bottom and who always wanted to know everything – about everyone.

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Under Mielke's tutelage, Honecker mastered the workings of Stasi and security machinery and shared his passion for secrecy and intrigue, using his position of undeclared heir apparent with energy and skill. He approved of Mielke's astonishing network of surveillance which employed a vast web of informants and operatives tracking opponents and detractors to the ends of the earth. Honecker's responsibility for military and security issues involved close contact with General Willi Stoph and Karl Maron, the head of the People's Police. 'They were, so to speak, placed under my control,' he explained. 'The greatest achievement of that time was that, despite all the attacks on the work of the central committee of the SED and its politburo, the GDR was successfully defended, and a secure basis was laid to withstand all the storms of that time.' In Mielke, Honecker and Ulbricht had found a dogged defender.